DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Embraced by God: The Secret of the Sukkah

Derech Hashem 4:8:2

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 8, paragraph 2 (first part) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 28 April 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Back after Pesah

Resuming after Pesah, the Rabbi said the class should finish the main book by Shavuot, and then learn the essays printed at the end of Derech Hashem through the summer.

He reviewed the whole book. Part 1 is about God; Part 2 about His relationship with humanity; Part 3 about the spiritual experiences of human beings, the soul and dreams; Part 4 about our service of God, through Torah study and through misvot. The misvot are constant (the six constant misvot: belief in God, love, fear, His unity, not serving other gods, and not straying after heart and eyes), daily (Shema, prayer, sisit, tefillin), seasonal, which the class is now learning, and circumstantial, such as mezuzah, which needs a house, to be learned in the last chapter.

Should tefillin be worn all day?

A participant asked why tefillin count as a daily misvah. The Rabbi added a point: the Torah never says to put on tefillin once each morning. The positive misvah is to wear them, really the whole day. We stopped for various reasons, such as not keeping the body clean or not keeping full concentration. Shema is explicitly morning and evening; tefillin are meant for all day, and we have cut back. "That's an interesting point."

The Clouds of Glory (paragraph 2)

Having discussed hames and massah before Pesah, the Ramhal now turns to Sukkot and the lulav.

The Clouds of Glory that surrounded Israel in the desert had a physical benefit. As we read on the seventh day of Pesah, they protected Israel and stopped the arrows. But with that physical protection came a spiritual envelopment: a light that separated Israel from all the nations and raised them above this world. The Torah tells us that in the desert their clothes did not wear out, and the shoes on their feet did not wear out.

This happened for forty years to prepare them, and its effect continued for all generations. Every day the light of the Shekhinah surrounds every Jew, if he wants it, separating him and

raising him, and this is renewed every Sukkot through the sukkah.

The Rabbi noted that this follows the opinion in the Gemara that the sukkah commemorates the Clouds of Glory. Another opinion says it commemorates actual booths, but the halachah follows the first: when sitting in the sukkah one should have in mind that it recalls the clouds.

Why in Tishri?

If the clouds were there for forty years, why celebrate now? Pesah and Shavuot mark specific events, but Sukkot does not. The Rabbi's own simple answer: God wanted a festival at the beginning of the spring and one at the beginning of the winter, and it could have been any time.

The Rishonim give two opposite reasons. The Rambam says Tishri has the right weather for sitting outside: summer is too hot and winter too cold, "clearly it's about Israel," not England. The Tur says God gave it in Tishri as a test: in summer, sitting outside would look natural, but in Tishri, when people go back indoors, it is clear you do it for the misvah. The Rabbi suggested each was writing from his own climate, one in a hot country and the other in Europe. Either way, the festival is not tied to an event on those days.

Embraced by God

From this the Rabbi explained a Kabbalistic practice cited in the Kaf HaHayim and the poskim (a recommendation, not strict halachah): not to bring a non-Jew into the sukkah. He related that Rav Mordekhai Eliyahu, when non-Jewish dignitaries visited him on Sukkot, would make one part of his sukkah invalid and seat them there. No one says a non-Jew may not eat massah. The difference is that the sukkah is about Israel being enveloped and set apart.

He brought the idea that the sukkah is like a hey, two walls and a bit, like an arm embracing you, as in the verse "and His right hand embraces me." "It's Hashem embracing us." Bringing a third party into that embrace goes against it.

He also mentioned, to show where it comes from, the Chabad custom not to sleep in the sukkah, because the surrounding light is too great to sleep in. He said he believes it is incorrect, since the halachah is to sleep in the sukkah, but it brings out the idea.

A sukkah of peace all year

This light can be reached at all times. That is why every night we say "spread over us Your sukkah of peace." Why mention a sukkah every night? Because its light is available all year.

The Ramhal says it surrounds every saddik. Why the saddik? For most of us there is no peace inside: a constant tug of war between the yeser tov and the yeser hara. The saddik has learned to channel his physical side for good, so peace lives within him, and the Shekhinah rests only where there is peace.

On Sukkot, every one of us gets that boost. Every action in the sukkah becomes a misvah, even eating, drinking and sleeping, everything except relieving oneself. That is the peace that lets the Shekhinah rest with us. And the clouds came in the merit of Aharon, whose way was to love and pursue peace.

"You can't pray for Pesah light during the year," because it belongs to its time. But the light of Sukkot was there all forty years, so we can pray for it every night.

The lulav

Halfway through the paragraph the Ramhal turns to the lulav: through it the light of God shines on Israel and crowns them, so that their enemies fear them, as the verse says, "all the nations of the earth will see that the name of Hashem is called upon you, and they will fear you." A participant suggested that the lulav looks like a call to war.

Really we should feel this immediately on taking the lulav; only our sins stop it, and it remains there in potential. The Rabbi noted that the misvah is to take the lulav, not to shake it. Once the species are held together, the misvah is done, which is why the etrog is first held upside down: otherwise the blessing would come after the misvah. The class will continue with the lulav next time.

Summary

- The Clouds of Glory protected Israel physically and enveloped them spiritually; the sukkah renews that light each year.
- Sukkot is not tied to an event on those days; the Rambam and the Tur give opposite reasons for Tishri.
- The sukkah is God's embrace of Israel, which is why some avoid bringing a non-Jew into it.
- Its light is open all year to those at peace within, like the saddik; on Sukkot even physical acts become misvot.
- Through the lulav God's light crowns Israel; the misvah is in the taking, which is why the etrog is first held upside down.

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